FOR PARENTS · SUPPORTING YOUR YOUNG PLAYER

LET YOUR CHILD LEAD

Their game, their journey

03

THE QUICK VERSION

> The kids who stay in sport the longest are usually the ones who chose it. When your child gets a real say in what they play, how much they play and whether they keep going, they build ownership, motivation and a love of being active that can last a lifetime.

WHAT'S REALLY GOING ON

Children can tell very quickly whether sport is "for them" or "for us." If they sense that your approval depends on them playing, scoring or staying, pressure replaces joy. The most important message you can send is that your love is never on the line, whatever they choose.

WAYS TO HAND OVER THE STEERING WHEEL

1. **Offer choices.** Team or individual? Football, futsal, athletics, swimming? Let them try a few things.
2. **Ask before you sign up.** "Do you want to play again next season?" is a real question. Wait for a real answer.
3. **Let them set the goal.** Maybe it's making friends, maybe it's a rep team. Their goal, not yours.
4. **Separate love from performance.** Make sure they know you're proud of who they are, not how they played.

Your dreams aren't their dreams (and that's okay)

Many of us carry our own sporting hopes. Notice when your excitement is about you, and gently set it aside. Your child gets to write their own story.

TRY THIS

1. **If they want to quit, ask why first**
   Bored? Friend left? Tricky coach? Nervous? Too much on? Many reasons can be fixed.

2. **Agree on a fair finish line**
   Finishing the term or season teaches commitment to the team. Then the choice is theirs.

3. **Say the most important sentence**
   "Whatever you decide, I'm proud of you."

4. **Keep the door open**
   Plenty of kids step away and come back later, refreshed and keen.

5. **Follow their interests**
   If they love goalkeeping, futsal or a totally different sport, go with it.

SAY THIS, NOT THAT

SAY THIS	NOT THAT
"What would you like to play this year?"	~~"You're doing football because I did."~~
"It's your choice. I'll back you either way."	~~"After everything we've spent on this?"~~
"I love watching you, whatever you play."	~~"You'll regret it if you quit."~~

QUICK SELF-CHECK

- [ ] My child chose the sport (or sports) they play
- [ ] I've asked what they want from this season
- [ ] They know my love doesn't depend on football
- [ ] I'd support them if they wanted to try something else

Can't tick them all yet? That's normal. Pick one to work on this week.

COACH'S CORNER

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No one can make a player love the game. Our job as adults is to keep the door open and make it a place they want to walk through.

THE FUTURE BALLER TEAM